

IN SYNC: (From left) Ruby, Sunderlal and blind students from Jyothi School



Notes of Distinction

A music school's special programme reaches out to differently-abled and visually-impaired children

■ **By Stephen David**

Ray Charles, Art Tatum and Stevie Wonder are just a few examples of famous visually-challenged musicians who continue to gratify our senses with their brilliant music. The Outreach Mission Project of the Bangalore School of Music (BSM) founded by mezzo-soprano Aruna Sunderlal, 68, has been training the city's very own Wonders and Tatums for the past 21 years. For instance, Fatima and Ravi, both 12, who are learning to play the piano and read musical notations in Braille. They are among nine students from the city's Jyothi School for the Blind—the beneficiaries of BSM's Outreach Project—run by Franciscan nuns from Poland. About 10 to 15 per cent of the nearly 500 students who train here comprise those selected under the Outreach programme.

Sunderlal began BSM in her century-old bungalow in 1987 with small amounts of public donations. After initial struggle, the classes have now begun in the new East West Music Centre in the northern part of the city.

Ruby Alphonse, 41, visually-challenged by birth, is an integral part of the Outreach Project and teaches piano to visually-impaired children. "Being blind, I am able to relate to them better," says the music missionary. Ruby plays with her



left hand while reading the Braille notes with her right. She then memorises bar after bar and repeats the procedure in reverse. It takes her about 7-10 days to learn a piece. "It's a great opportunity for these children," says Ruby after finishing a class in BSM's new Rs 1-crore East West Music Centre, which boasts of a 260-seater auditorium, private music

studios, library and a soon-to-start roof-top café. The 4,000-sq ft land was granted by the state government and then BSM chairman—nuclear scientist and pianist Raja Ramanna—provided initial funds to kick start the centre. The school's tie-ups with institutions like the Royal College of Music in Sweden and The Conservatory of Lausanne in Switzerland mean better instruments and teaching opportunities.

The teachers working on this project also travel to orphanages and run music therapy sessions for autistic children. They have been working with children of prison inmates, but for now these classes are on hold and will resume after BSM's move to the new centre is complete.

"I dream to see children from all rungs of society, especially the differently-abled, visually-impaired and those part of Outreach largely benefiting from this programme," says Sunderlal. She asks for support and hopes to one day hear western classical music, while walking down the street. ■